FRENCH IMMERSION SURVIVAL KIT

# You don't need to speak French to help your child in French Immersion

Three printable pages for parents and caregivers who don't speak French: a 10-minute nightly routine, a checklist of questions for your child's teacher, and a plain-English guide to the two French past tenses that trip up so many immersion students.

> "It is not necessary for a parent/caregiver to speak French for a child to thrive in French Immersion." — Toronto District School Board, French Immersion FAQ

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The 10-minute nightly routine, with 10 easy French phrases

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Questions to ask your child's teacher, and when to ask for help

**4**
Passé composé or imparfait? One idea, three questions

## TDSB French Immersion: key dates for September 2027

| Program | Who can apply | Application window |
|---|---|---|
| **Early French Immersion (JK entry)** | Children born in 2023 who live in the City of Toronto and aren't already in a French program | Opens **Mon Nov 2, 2026, 9:00 a.m.**<br>Closes **Fri Nov 27, 2026, 4:00 p.m.**<br>Offers to on-time applicants begin Jan 4, 2027 |
| **Middle French Immersion (Grade 4 entry)** | Children born in 2018 (in Grade 3 now) who live in the City of Toronto and aren't already in a French program | Opens **Mon Jan 4, 2027, 9:00 a.m.**<br>Closes **Fri Jan 29, 2027, 4:00 p.m.**<br>Offers to on-time applicants begin in February 2027 |

- Apply online, then watch your email regularly, including your junk and spam folders.
- Late applications (until May 31, 2027, 4:00 p.m.) go on a late waitlist and are considered only if space is available.
- **How much French?** Early Immersion: all French until the end of Grade 3 (some specialist subjects may be in English), then 50% French and 50% English in Grades 4–8. Middle Immersion: all French in Grades 4–5, then 75% French and 25% English in Grades 6–8 (Science and English taught in English).

Sources: Toronto District School Board, "Early French Immersion (JK Entry)", https://www.tdsb.on.ca/Elementary-School/School-Choices/French-Programs/Application-Early-French-Immersion, and "Middle French Immersion (Grade 4 entry)", https://www.tdsb.on.ca/Elementary-School/School-Choices/French-Programs/Application-Middle-French-Immersion, both checked Oct 21, 2026. Dates can change: always confirm on the TDSB site. Outside Toronto, each school board sets its own dates.

### How to use this kit

Print pages 2 to 4. Put page 2 on the fridge, bring page 3 to your next parent-teacher conversation, and keep page 4 next to the homework spot. Each page works on its own.

# 1 The 10-minute nightly routine

Same time every evening, for example after dinner. Your child does the French; you ask the questions and cheer.

**2 min**

### Ask about the day

Ask: **« Qu'est-ce que tu as appris aujourd'hui ? »** (What did you learn today?). Let them answer in French first, then explain in English.

**3 min**

### Read aloud

Your child reads one page of their French book to you. You don't need to understand it: listen for confident, smooth reading and say “Encore une fois!” for a tricky line.

**2 min**

### Teach me one word

Your child picks one new word, says it, and explains it. Write it in the “Tonight's word” box below.

**2 min**

### Check the homework, not the French

Is it done? Is the agenda signed? Ask them to tell you, in English, what the task was asking.

**1 min**

### End on a win

Praise the effort, not the mistakes. Finish with **« Bonne nuit ! »**

## 10 phrases you can say tonight

| French | Say it like (rough guide) | Meaning |
|---|---|---|
| **Bonjour !** | *bohn-ZHOOR* | Hello! |
| **Comment ça va ?** | *koh-mahn sah VAH* | How are you? |
| **Qu'est-ce que tu as appris ?** | *KESS-kuh tew ah ah-PREE* | What did you learn? |
| **Montre-moi !** | *MOHN-truh mwah* | Show me! |
| **Explique-moi en anglais.** | *ex-PLEEK mwah ahn ahn-GLEH* | Explain it to me in English. |
| **Lis-moi une page.** | *LEE mwah ewn PAHZH* | Read me a page. |
| **Encore une fois !** | *ahn-KOR ewn FWAH* | One more time! |
| **C'est super !** | *say sew-PAIR* | That's great! |
| **Je suis fier / fière de toi.** | *zhuh swee fee-AIR duh TWAH* | I'm proud of you. |
| **Bonne nuit !** | *bun NWEE* | Good night! |

Pronunciation guides are rough. Your child will happily correct you, and that's part of the fun. Use *fier* if you're a dad, *fière* if you're a mom (both sound almost the same).

### Do

- Keep it short, at the same time each day.
- Let your child be the teacher.
- Keep reading in your home language too.

### Don't

- Turn it into a test or a punishment.
- Worry about your own accent.
- Do the homework for them.

### Tonight's word

Stick it on the fridge.

# 2 Questions to ask your child's teacher

Bring this page to a parent-teacher interview, or use it in an email before report cards. It's fine to ask in English. Tick the ones you want to ask.

### Speaking and listening

- ☐ Does my child speak French in class, or mostly listen?
- ☐ Can they follow instructions given only in French?
- ☐ What could we listen to or watch at home?

### Reading

- ☐ What reading level is my child at in French?
- ☐ Which books should they bring home, and how often?
- ☐ Should they read aloud to me or on their own?

### Writing

- ☐ What does good writing look like at this grade?
- ☐ Which mistakes should we not worry about yet?
- ☐ Can you share an example of their work?

### Support

- ☐ What is one thing we can practise at home this month?
- ☐ How is my child doing compared with what you expect at this point in the year?
- ☐ What extra help is available at school?

### Language gap or learning gap? A rule of thumb

Struggling in French is normal, especially in the first years. Ask the teacher whether the same difficulty shows up **in English too** (reading, spelling, attention, memory). If it only happens in French, it's usually a language gap that practice and time can close. If it also shows up in English, ask the school what support it can offer.

This is a conversation starter, not a diagnosis. Only the school and qualified professionals can assess learning needs.

### Free French to watch and listen to at home

- **TFO** (tfo.org): Ontario's French-language public broadcaster, with shows and films for children and teens.
- **Radio-Canada** (ici.radio-canada.ca): French news, radio and podcasts (OHdio), including content for young people.

Suggestions only. Winny French isn't affiliated with TFO or Radio-Canada.

### Notes from the meeting

## 3 Passé composé or imparfait?

Choosing between French's two everyday past tenses is one of the trickiest topics for immersion students in the junior and intermediate grades. You don't need to conjugate anything: you need one idea and three questions.

**The one idea:** the **imparfait** is the film running in the background; the **passé composé** is the snapshot of what happened.

*Il faisait froid et il neigeait. Je lisais dans ma chambre.* (background → imparfait)
*Soudain, les lumières se sont éteintes ! Mon frère s'est réveillé.* (events → passé composé)

| Imparfait: the film running | Passé composé: the snapshot |
|---|---|
| Descriptions, weather, feelings, habits, what was going on | One completed event, a sudden change, a series of actions |
| Looks like: je lisais, il faisait, nous étions | Looks like: j'ai lu, il a fait, nous sommes allés |
| Clue words: d'habitude, souvent, tous les jours, pendant que, quand j'étais petit(e) | Clue words: soudain, tout à coup, un jour, hier, d'abord, ensuite, enfin |

### Three questions to ask your child, in English

1. Is this **background** (weather, feelings, description) or an **event**?
2. Did it happen **once**, or did it **keep happening**?
3. Is it a **snapshot** (passé composé) or the **film running** (imparfait)?

Clue words help, but they're hints, not rules. The meaning decides.

### Quick quiz to do together

1. Quand j'étais petit, j'(aller) _____ au parc tous les samedis.
2. Nous (regarder) _____ un film quand le téléphone a sonné.
3. Tout à coup, le chien (sauter) _____ sur la table.
4. Ce matin-là, il (faire) _____ beau.
5. L'été dernier, nous (visiter) _____ Québec.

Answers: 1. allais (habit) · 2. regardions (what was going on) · 3. a sauté (sudden event) · 4. faisait (description) · 5. avons visité (one completed event)

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